

Rivers Brahmaputra (20 km at its widest), Ganges, and its distributary Hooghly, an estuary that flows into the Bay of Bengal. This trip typically took four months and a rail link seemed the most obvious choice, given that Assam's neighbours – Bengal in the west and Burma in the east – were already so well-connected.

The first connection

Tired of spoilt tea, poor communication, and bad road conditions that often led to little or no food supply, tea plantation owner and surgeon, Dr John Berry White, proposed a metre-gauge line between the town of Dibrugarh and Sadiya – the most northeastern British frontier. The Government of India agreed and White formed the Assam Railways and Trading Company in 1881. When he could not raise the required money, well-known British railway engineer Benjamin Piercy stepped in. However, the focus was no longer connecting the plantations; it now included rights for coal, oil mining, and timber.

Work began in full swing and the lines were laid from Dibrugarh to the River Dehring with a branch line from the coalfield town of Makum to the River Talap. Workers came from all over the country while all the equipment – from screws and nails to locomotives and rails – came from England. Within a few months, the isolated plantations buzzed with activity; the railway company brought in 5,872 workers and 100 European overseers. Housing colonies sprouted to accommodate all, and soon, in August 1882, Mohonamukh Ghat near Dibrugarh was connected to Dinjan near the town of Tinsukia. By 1883, all 124 km of the Dibrugarh–Sadiya Railway (DSR) in Lakhimpur were connected and open for business.

Coupling-uncoupling

The success of the DSR emboldened other parts of Assam, resulting in the laying of three other lines, including the 48-km-long Jorhat–Kokilamukh line. Constructed by the Government and officially inaugurated in 1884, the first passenger train ran on this line in February 1886. The snail-paced, 2-ft gauge Jorhat Provincial Railway, which is the only line in India whose gauge was converted twice, from narrow gauge to metre gauge, and then finally to broad gauge, may have had many